

of an HOA is that they use your fees to maintain common areas, so you want to make sure they're actually going to do what they say they will.

Finally, before you move on to anything else in the process, sit down with your trusty calendar and enter every date and deadline from the contract. Consider entering these dates one day in advance. You do not want to miss a deadline—it's a very silly reason to fall out of contract or lose your earnest money.

EARNEST MONEY AND WIRE FRAUD

Another early step is to contact your title company for instructions on how to deposit your earnest money, since this is one of the earliest deadlines you must meet. As the buyer, you will most likely use a wire transfer to send your down payment to the title company. Cashier's checks used to be accepted but have become too easy to fake, so many closing companies only allow wire transfers.

Along with any extra money due at closing, earnest money is the biggest chunk of change you will put toward your home. If you've never sent more than \$5,000 electronically to someone else, put on some deodorant, get ready to sweat a little, and please read this next section carefully.

Unfortunately, wire fraud has recently taken the real estate industry by storm. It is a very real and devastating problem. The scammer hacks into the email account of someone who is involved in a real estate transaction (or creates an almost identical account) and contacts the buyer, telling them that the bank account routing information they were given was incorrect. Here's the new info, send me my money, and have a nice day.

The buyer then changes their wire instructions and the money is sent to the scammer—and lost forever. We're talking tens or even hundreds of thousands of dollars. Poof! Gone. Irretrievable.

Here's the skinny, and pay close attention:

- Your title/closing company will not change their wire instructions at the last minute.
- Your title/closing company will not accidentally give you the wrong instructions and then need to change them.